

The oldest ice core, found in Antarctica, is nearly **2 million** years old.



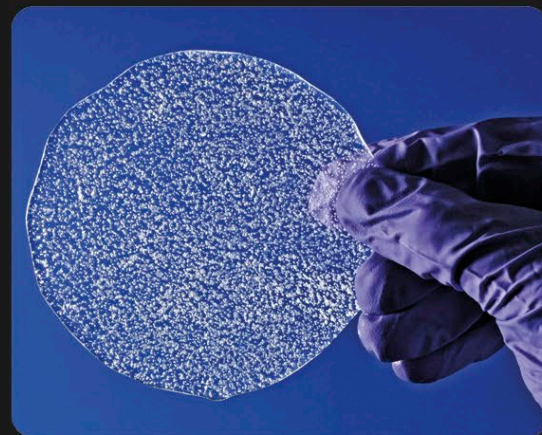
2 Preparing the core for study

The block of ice is carefully removed from the drill and prepared as a sample. Ice cores must be kept below -0.4°F (-18°C) to prevent the gases in the air bubbles from escaping the ice. The cores are transported in a mobile freezer.



3 Storage

The cores, which can be miles long, are cut into small 3.3-ft (1-m) sections and stored at -32.8°F (-36°C). This lab in Colorado stores 11.8 miles (19 km) of ice cores for research.



4 Analyzing samples

Researchers cut thin slices from the cores to analyze the trapped air bubbles in detail. Each slice provides a snapshot of the atmosphere and climate conditions at a particular point in history, including information about volcanic activity and wind patterns.